THE CHANGE-MAKERS

ADANI WILMAR

- The joint venture between the Adani Group and the Singapore-based Kuok Khoon Hong's Wilmar International makes edible oils like soyabean oil, palm oil, sunflower oil, rice bran oil, mustard oil, groundnut oil, cottonseed oil and blended oil
- It is one of the largest importers of crude edible oil
- Its factory at Mundra in Gujarat with a capacity to process 5,000 tonnes of oil daily is among India's largest

PATANJALI FOODS

- Formerly known as Ruchi Soya Industries, Patanjali Foods boasts an extensive product lineup of soyabean edible oils
- An essential aspect is its reliance on sourcing raw materials from local farmers
- The firm is a significant contributor to the National Mission on Edible Oils. The initiative seeks to establish plantation of 10 million palm saplings, covering an area of 1.5–2 million acres over the next five years

15%
India's share of the world's edible oil imports

₹1.57 LAKH CRORE
India's edible oil imports bill in the oil year ending October 2022

India gets its palm oil—the substantial component of import—from Indonesia and Malaysia, while a small quantity of crude soft oil, including soybean oil, comes from as far as Brazil and Argentina. Ukraine and Russia supply sunflower oil.

WHY IT IS A GAME CHANGER

Driven by an ambition to pare down its dependence on external sources, India unveiled its visionary National Mission on Edible Oils in 2021. It aims to enhance the edible oilseeds production and oils availability. Under the mission, the country's cultivated area of oil palm has been set a target of 1 million hectares by 2026, up from 350,000 hectares in 2019. This apart, nearly 2.8 million ha. of suitable land has been identified in 18 states—the Northeast region being particularly promising. Once rooted in the soil, palms take three to four years to become productive and bear fruit for a remarkable span of 20 to 25 years. This step, if navigated with enough tact and foresight to avoid the ecological devastation palm oil monocropping brought in Southeast Asian rainforests, possesses the latent power to rewrite India's edible oil story.



"The National Mission on Edible Oils is on the right path, but requires acceleration as well as more intensive policy support"

– ASHWANI MAHAJAN
National Co-convenor, Swadeshi Jagran Manch

WHAT INDIA NEEDS TO MASTER

Climate change poses a significant challenge to India's ambitions of expanding its edible oil production capacity. This is particularly evident in the context of the new oil palm plantations, with their long gestation period before maturation and subsequent harvest. India also grapples with uncertainties surrounding the adoption of genetically modified (GM) technology for oilseed cultivation. For instance, the nation's ongoing deliberations over GM Mustard highlight the intricate debates and concerns surrounding genetically modified organisms. Furthermore, there has been little progress in the acceptance and deployment of modified versions of soybeans, groundnuts etc.

The deliberations within regulatory bodies and even higher judicial authorities reflect the ambiguity surrounding the potential ramifications of GM technology on our health and the environment. The lack of clarity has led to a prolonged period of uncertainty, hindering the country's ability to harness the benefits of advanced agricultural practices. The path that's chosen will have to be tailored to the need of reducing our reliance on imports to meet the gaps in domestic production. ■